

Right Sticker, Same Bin

An Unannounced Audit Finds No Link Between Labelling Compliance and Discarded Food

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Background

Facilities' monthly sustainability report credits its shared-kitchen labelling scheme with declining food waste, citing a rising compliance percentage as the evidence. Nobody has weighed what a clear-out actually discards against that same figure.

Aims

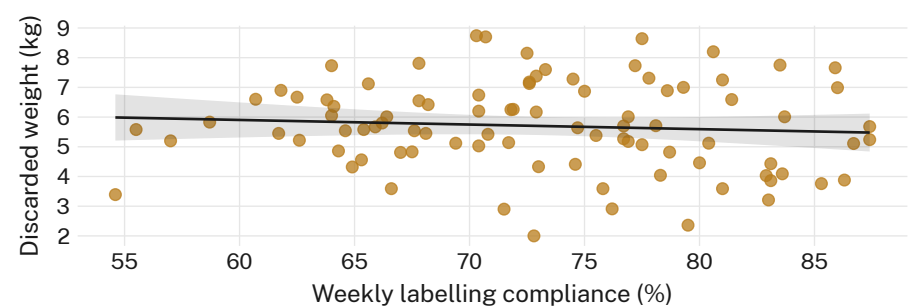
- Test whether weekly labelling compliance predicts discarded-food weight at clear-out
- Log discarded weight directly, independent of Facilities' reported percentage
- Establish whether the compliance figure is fit to stand in for the waste outcome it is cited against

Methods

- 9 shared kitchens · unannounced pre-clear-out weigh-in · 10-week audit, March-May 2026
- Every item binned under the 48-hour unlabelled rule weighed and logged before disposal
- Facilities' officially reported weekly compliance percentage matched by kitchen and week; no interim result disclosed

Results

Reported labelling compliance rose from 61% to 83% across the audit window. Weekly discarded weight showed no reliable association with it ($r = -0.08$, $n = 90$ kitchen-weeks).



Across 9 shared kitchens over 10 weeks (Mar-May 2026, $n = 90$ kitchen-weeks), weekly labelling compliance climbed from 61% to 83% while discarded-food weight held flat ($r = -0.08$).

Discussion & conclusions

A rising compliance line and a flat waste line ran side by side for ten straight weeks. The percentage tracks who reached for a sticker, not what left the fridge. Facilities' sustainability report still leads with the compliance figure as its evidence for the scheme's effect on waste, unrevised by this audit or any other. Next: test whether discarded volume tracks any input Facilities currently measures, or whether the fridge is simply indifferent to all of them.

References

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Discarded weight audited only; no item opened or handled after removal; no individual identified.

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